

MIG-5

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-5

Age: 45

Gender: Female

Country of origin: China

Host country: Australia

Years in host country: 12

Occupation: Small Business Owner

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I moved to Australia twelve years ago together with my husband, seeking better economic prospects and a way to escape the intense, relentless competition of life in urban China. We wanted our son to have a less pressured education than the Chinese system would have imposed on him, and we longed for a cleaner environment and a slower, more balanced pace of life. Australia's geographic proximity to Asia and its already substantial and growing Chinese community made the move feel more accessible and less frightening than relocating somewhere with no familiar faces at all. We arrived with some capital and a plan to start a business, which gave us a measure of security, though nothing could fully prepare us for how much everyday life would differ from what we had known.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion, in my view, means that my business is patronised by all Australians and not only by members of the Chinese community, and that my son is never treated as a perpetual foreigner in the country where he has spent almost his entire life. It means being able to participate fully in civic life, to have my voice genuinely heard on matters that affect my family and my neighbourhood, and to feel in my bones that this land is authentically my home and not merely a place where I happen to live and work. Inclusion is the sense that I am a citizen in the fullest sense, woven into the community, rather than a long-term guest whose belonging is always conditional.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: During the pandemic, anti-Chinese xenophobia surged dramatically and frighteningly, and I felt it directly. People openly blamed us for the virus, as though ordinary Chinese-Australians going about their lives bore some responsibility for a global catastrophe, and I was verbally abused while simply doing my grocery shopping. On one occasion a stranger told my son, a boy who speaks with a broad Australian accent and has lived here since he was small, to 'go back to China,' a country he barely knows. It was terrifying and deeply, profoundly unjust. We had lived here peacefully and productively for a decade, contributing and paying taxes and raising a family, and yet almost overnight we became convenient scapegoats for something entirely beyond our control.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The language was challenging in the beginning, and Australian slang in particular confused me endlessly, since so little of it appears in any textbook and it changes constantly. Beyond the language, though, I struggled most with isolation and with how much I missed my extended family, who remained on the other side of the world. Building a business in an unfamiliar regulatory environment, learning the rules and the paperwork and the expectations of Australian customers, was stressful and full of costly mistakes. For a long time, despite all my efforts and my growing competence, I still felt like an outsider looking in, uncertain whether I would ever truly be accepted or whether I would always be regarded as somehow not quite belonging.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: My business interactions are mostly positive, and I have many loyal customers of every background, though I do sense at times that some customers instinctively prefer businesses they perceive as more 'Australian,' a preference that is rarely stated but occasionally palpable. My employees come from a real mix of backgrounds and we work together well and harmoniously. The multicultural character of Australian cities means that my Chinese heritage is, in the commercial context, usually an asset rather than a liability, opening certain doors and building trust with certain customers, even if it occasionally closes others. On the whole, running my own business has given me a sense of independence and rootedness that has helped me feel that I belong.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I maintain strong ties to Chinese culture through festivals like Lunar New Year, which we celebrate fully and joyfully, through cooking the traditional dishes of my region, and through my son's ongoing Mandarin lessons, which I insist upon so that he does not lose the language of his grandparents. At the same time, we have wholeheartedly embraced Australian outdoor life, the barbecues, the beach culture, the love of sport and open space. I identify comfortably as Chinese-Australian, holding both parts of that identity without contradiction, though I am aware that the balance between them shifts with each generation, and that my son leans more toward the Australian side than I do, which is natural and, I think, healthy.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: Media coverage of China as a geopolitical rival and threat spills over, often unfairly, into how ordinary Chinese-Australians are perceived by their neighbours. We are sometimes viewed with a vague suspicion, as though our loyalty to Australia were somehow in question simply because of our ethnic origin, as though we could not possibly be fully committed to the country we have chosen and built our lives in. This political tension makes everyday life quietly harder and occasionally lonelier. I dearly wish that the media, and the public conversation more broadly, would clearly distinguish between the Chinese government and its policies on the one hand and the Chinese people living here peacefully as fellow Australians on the other.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: When we first arrived, there were community organisations that helped us with the practicalities of settling in, though in truth we relied more heavily on the established Chinese network of earlier

migrants than on any formal government programme. Those personal connections, people who had walked the same path a few years before us, were invaluable. Australia's official multicultural policies are decent and well-intentioned, and I do not want to be ungrateful, but the specific support available for older migrants trying to learn English while simultaneously running a business and raising a family could be considerably stronger and more accessible than it currently is. Much of the burden fell on us to work it out ourselves.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My son is thoroughly Australian, speaking with a broad Aussie accent and passionately following cricket and football, more at home here than anywhere else on earth. Yet even he faced ugly racism during the COVID period, which genuinely shook his sense of belonging and made him question, for the first time, whether he was really accepted here. He is proud of his Chinese roots and does not hide them, but he becomes understandably frustrated when he is treated as foreign in the only country he has ever really known. This generation, I firmly believe, deserves to be seen simply and unconditionally as Australian, which is precisely what they are in every way that should matter.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: Reducing xenophobia requires leaders to condemn racism swiftly and unambiguously, particularly during moments of crisis when the scapegoating of minorities predictably spikes and can turn dangerous. Education about the long history of Chinese contributions to Australia, going back generations to the goldfields and beyond, would help correct the impression that we are recent and unwelcome arrivals. But personal relationships matter most of all in my experience; when people come to know a Chinese family personally, as neighbours or friends or the owners of a shop they frequent, the abstract stereotypes crumble. We need more genuine cross-cultural friendship and less of the polite but distant coexistence that keeps communities parallel but separate.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to continue growing my business and perhaps, in time, to mentor other migrant entrepreneurs who are facing the same barriers and uncertainties that I once faced, passing on the hard-won knowledge that no one was there to give me. I want my son to feel unquestionably and permanently Australian while still cherishing and understanding his Chinese heritage, so that neither part of him is ever a source of shame or conflict. And someday, when circumstances allow, I would like to travel more freely between the two countries, maintaining our family connections across the ocean, without ever feeling that I must choose one identity and abandon the other.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to new migrants is to be resilient and patient, because genuine acceptance takes considerable time and cannot be rushed or forced. Learn English as thoroughly as you possibly can, because it empowers you in every single situation, from business dealings to defending yourself against unfair treatment. Make a real effort to engage with the broader community and not only with your own ethnic group, however comfortable and easy that group may feel, because integration requires reaching outward. And during the hard times, and there will be hard times, try to remember that the great majority of people are fundamentally kind and decent, even when a loud and hurtful few are cruel.